

Getting Help

We will always stumble across tools whose optional parameters we do not know from memory or tools we have never seen before. Therefore it is vital to know how we can help ourselves to get familiar with those tools. The first two ways are the man pages and the help functions. It is always a good idea to familiarize ourselves with the tool we want to try first. We will also learn some possible tricks with some of the tools that we thought were not possible. In the man pages, we will find the detailed manuals with detailed explanations.

Syntax:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ man <tool>
```

Let us have a look at an example:

Example:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ man curl
```

Getting Help

```
curl(1)                                Curl Manual

NAME
    curl - transfer a URL

SYNOPSIS
    curl [options] [URL...]

DESCRIPTION
    curl is a tool to transfer data from or to a server, using one of the supported protocols (DICT, FILE,
    IMAP, IMAPS, LDAP, LDAPS, POP3, POP3S, RTMP, RTSP, SCP, SFTP, SMB, SMBS, SMTP, SMTPS, TELNET, and
    TFTP).

    curl offers a busload of useful tricks like proxy support, user authentication, FTP upload, HTTP post,
    cookies, etc.

    curl is powered by libcurl for all transfer-related features. See libcurl(3) for details.

Manual page curl(1) line 1 (press h for help or q to quit)
```

After looking at some examples, we can also quickly look at the optional parameters without browsing through the complete documentation. We have several ways to do that.

Syntax:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ <tool> --help
```

Example:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ curl --help

Usage: curl [options...] <url>
  --abstract-unix-socket <path> Connect via abstract Unix domain socket
  --anyauth             Pick any authentication method
  -a, --append          Append to target file when uploading
  --basic               Use HTTP Basic Authentication
  --cacert <file>       CA certificate to verify peer against
  --capath <dir>        CA directory to verify peer against
  -E, --cert <certificate[:password]> Client certificate file and password
<SNIP>
```

We can also use the short version of it:

Syntax:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ <tool> -h
```

Example:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ curl -h

Usage: curl [options...] <url>
  --abstract-unix-socket <path> Connect via abstract Unix domain socket
  --anyauth             Pick any authentication method
  -a, --append          Append to target file when uploading
  --basic               Use HTTP Basic Authentication
  --cacert <file>       CA certificate to verify peer against
  --capath <dir>        CA directory to verify peer against
  -E, --cert <certificate[:password]> Client certificate file and password
<SNIP>
```

As we can see, the results from each other do not differ in this example. Another tool that can be useful in the beginning is [apropos](#).

Each manual page has a short description available within it. This tool searches the descriptions for instances of a given keyword.

Syntax:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ apropos <keyword>
```

Example:

Getting Help

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ apropos sudo

sudo (8)                - execute a command as another user
sudo.conf (5)           - configuration for sudo front end
sudo_plugin (8)         - Sudo Plugin API
sudo_root (8)           - How to run administrative commands
sudedit (8)             - execute a command as another user
sudoers (5)             - default sudo permissions and rules
```

sudoers (5)

sudoers (8)

visudo (8)

- default sudo security policy plugin

- replay sudo session logs

- edit the sudoers file

Another useful resource to get help if we have issues to understand a long command is: <https://explainshell.com/>

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